Riverdale was much tougher than his Indian schools, even though he had to take fewer courses in the preparatory programme.

He worked hard to earn a special mention in the yearbook for surprising ‘many, including his teacher, in Physics class by his knowledge of engineering principles’. He wrote for the *Review*, a school publication, as well. Ratan was also an active member of the Cosmopolitan Club, whose purpose was to build closer relationships between American and non-American students. The club held discussions with eminent speakers and organized social events. He would speak at these meetings, sharing his knowledge about India. His schoolmate Bill Mow comments that Ratan always kept his cool during the heated debates at the Cosmopolitan Club. His skills got him to represent his school for The New York Times Youth Forum hosted by the famous moderator, Dorothy Gordon.

When it came to sports, his performance was delightfully impressive. Mow says that Ratan was at a disadvantage when it came to playing American football, a contact sport, because he was thin-built, which made it hard for him to match the heavier-built American kids. But he took up another popular American game, baseball, so seriously that he was selected for the Junior Varsity. Similar was his enthusiasm for fencing, for which too he was selected to the Varsity team.

After completing his studies at Riverdale, Ratan cleared his College Board examinations and applied for a mechanical engineering course at three prominent institutions: Cornell University, Massachusetts Institute of Technology (MIT) and Rensselaer Polytechnic Institute (RPI). The interview at MIT came first but it was on a wintry, cold and wet day in Boston. The city has very cold winter months and is partly cloudy year-round. Ratan, who abhors the cold, wanted only to complete the interview and make haste to escape. His second interview was at Cornell. Ratan arrived at the university on a ‘glorious spring day’, he recalls. He reminisces that on reaching Ithaca, New York, where Cornell is located, he told himself that this was where he ‘wanted to go to school’. The bright sun virtually made the decision for him, even though Ithaca too experiences bitterly cold winter months. The fact that many of Ratan’s classmates from Riverdale had been admitted to the university was, as he recalls, also a ‘magnet’ that influenced his decision. Another reason was that his father’s close friend Ed Vinnicombe was a Cornellian. He and his wife, Sylvia, were like Ratan’s surrogate parents. The couple lived in Baltimore and their